

FETAL DEVELOPMENT

FROM THE EIGHTH WEEK, WHEN THE BABY STARTS TO BE KNOWN AS A FETUS, ITS BODY GROWS LARGER AND STRONGER.

CHANGES IN THE FETUS

By 12 weeks, the fetus has a large head compared with the rest of its body, and all major internal organs have developed. By around 16 weeks, the fetus can move its limbs vigorously. As its growth continues, the fetus becomes leaner, but by the seventh to eighth month, it starts to accumulate fat and to assume the “chubby” appearance of the newborn.

36 WEEKS

The fetus is now somewhat restricted by the uterus. The side of the placenta facing the fetus is smooth and circular in outline, with the umbilical cord attached at the centre.

Umbilical cord

Immunological, nutritional, and hormonal link with the mother

Amnion

Strong, transparent sac within the chorion; it encloses amniotic fluid

Amniotic fluid

Shock-absorbing liquid in which the fetus “floats”

Chorion

Main protective sac around the fetus

Cervical plug

Plug of thick mucus that blocks the cervix to prevent infection

Cervix

Lower part of the uterus that extends into the vagina; it stays tightly closed until birth is near

Vagina

Birth canal

